

PARACHUTES AND GLIDERS

ONE OF THE MOST IMPRESSIVE sights in the war was the departure for a major airborne operation, the air thick with hundreds of transport aircraft carrying parachutists and towing gliders. Unfortunately, this vision of order and power had a tendency to degenerate into something approaching chaos over the drop zone. Pilot Pierre Clostermann described the Allied airborne assault on the east bank of the Rhine in March 1945 as “an apocalyptic spectacle. Thousands of white parachutes dropped through an inferno of heavy, medium, and light flak, while Dakotas crashed in flames and gliders rammed high-tension cables in showers of blue sparks.”

German successes early in the war convinced the Americans and British of the value of airborne operations. But airborne assaults were technically difficult to carry off. A man floating down on a parachute was desperately vulnerable if surprise had not been achieved. Despite rigorous training, paratroops were often widely scattered by the time they reached the ground and separated from their equipment. When the enemy reacted, the paratroops either needed to join up rapidly with friendly forces advancing on the ground or be backed up by close air support and aerial resupply.

Gliders could carry in equipment such as jeeps and light artillery as well as troops. A glider had a pilot and copilot sitting side by side, communicating with the “tug” pilot by a telephone wire in the tow rope. They did not have an easy job. If there was turbulence, or the glider inadvertently strayed into the tug’s slipstream, the tow rope could break, leaving the glider to an uncertain fate. Those that reached the target zone had to land at upward of 70mph (110kph) on whatever clear strip of land they could locate. Inevitably, landing accidents were common.

Allied large-scale airborne operations – for example, during the D-Day landings and in the ill-fated Operation Market Garden in September 1944 – rarely went according to plan, but they sometimes proved useful.

“Thousands of white parachutes dropped through an inferno of flak, while Dakotas crashed in flames.”

PILOT PIERRE CLOSTERMANN
AIRBORNE ASSAULT ON THE RHINE, 1945

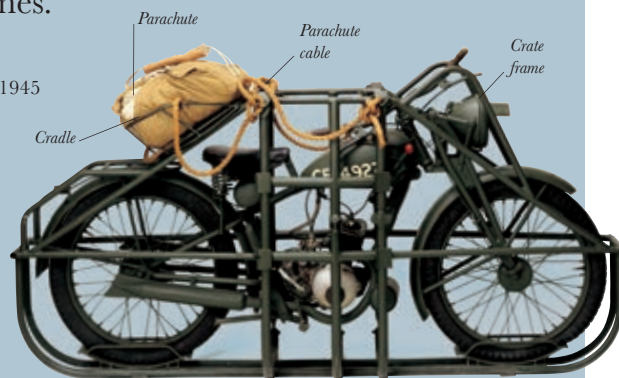
GETTING AIRBORNE

British paratroops stoop to enter a Hotspur glider during a training exercise in 1942. Airborne troops, who quickly earned a reputation as elite units, added an extra dimension to warfare, allowing generals to insert forces behind enemy lines, seizing key points such as bridges or airfields.



OPERATION MARKET GARDEN

On September 17, 1944 some 10,000 Allied airborne troops were sent into German-occupied Netherlands by parachute and glider to take key bridges over the rivers Maas, Waal, and Rhine. It fell short of its full objectives because of the failure to capture the heavily defended bridge at Arnhem.



PARADROPPABLE MOTORCYCLE

During World War II, containers holding weapons, ammunition, radios, and even motorcycles such as this one were parachuted in to supply troops. Often even larger vehicles were dropped, including jeeps, which needed up to four parachutes to land undamaged.